To Kill a Mockingbird: Characters

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Written by: Helen Cunningham
Reviewed by: Kate Lee
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Characters

Authors of fiction construct characters to embody concepts, represent ideas and convey the key themes they want to communicate. In To Kill a Mockingbird, Harper Lee employs characters to convey themes, explore societal issues, and provide insight into human nature. Each character serves a distinct purpose, adding depth and meaning to the novel.

Main characters

- Scout (Jean Louise Finch)
- Atticus Finch
- Jem Finch
- Boo Radley

Other characters

- Calpurnia
- Dill (Charles Baker Harris)
- Bob Ewell
- Mayella Ewell
- Tom Robinson
- Mrs Dubose
- Aunt Alexandra
- Miss Maudie Atkinson

Scout (Jean Louise Finch)

Scout (Jean Louise Finch)

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

as a child but is mediated by an adult
    - This adds a maturity and credibility to the events
    - By using the voice of a child, Lee is able to expose the injustices and absurdity of racism and discrimination
    - It also create **pathos** for the plight of Tom Robinson by interweaving her loss of innocence with his mistreatment

- Scout is intelligent and literate in contrast to her peers, who can only read and write in the "third grade"
- She is **precocious** and unafraid of speaking her mind:
    - This leads to her being punished at school when she explains why Walter Cunningham does not have his lunch money
    - However, this quality is shown to be important as it drives Scout to question the **social norms** that the community in the southern town of Maycomb, Alabama accept and **propagate**

- Scout understands that **segregation** does not **espouse** the American value of equality and realises this **hypocrisy**
- Scout is presented as a tomboy who defies gender stereotypes, choosing to wear "overalls" and "**britches**" rather than dresses:
    - Even when she is in a dress, she wears her overalls underneath
    - She defies traditional gender roles with her rejection of feminine clothing, symbolising her rebellious nature

- Following the conventions of the **bildungsroman** genre, Scout is shown to mature and grow throughout the text:
    - She embraces kindness and empathy **epitomised** by the evolution of her attitude towards Boo

- Similar to her community, she first considers Boo an outcast, but by the end she realises that he is a harmless, kind and vulnerable person:
    - This allows Lee to comment on Atticus's parenting style, and the importance of it in educating his children in empathy, kindness and tolerance
    - This may be seen as a Lee offering a wider critique of parenting and education as vital in overcoming the ills of society
    - By the end of the text, Scout **embodies** these qualities, suggesting that Atticus has been successful in raising her

Help me understand

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Always remember that fictional characters in texts are not real; they are constructs created by the author. Therefore, you should always think about what Harper Lee was trying to

Atticus Finch

Atticus Finch

- Atticus is a lawyer and state representative who takes on the Tom Robinson case even though he knows he will lose:
  - It causes him to be intimidated and **shunned** by others
  - He symbolises honour, bravery, heroism, intelligence and empathy and is the **moral compass** of the text
- Atticus rejects society's prejudices even when it puts him in harm's way and sets him apart from the rest of the town:
  - For example, he calls Tom Robinson "respectable" in court and visits his wife after his death:
    - Through his empathy, he considers Tom Robinson an equal and not as the **other,** undermining the idea of segregation
    - His shooting of the rabid dog becomes a **motif** for his attempt to **eradicate** racism in his community
- Atticus empathises with others, even though they do not do the same:
  - He helps Mr Cunningham with his legal affairs even though he cannot pay
  - He tells his children to hold their heads high and keep their fists down:
    - "No matter what anybody says to you, don't let 'em get your goat"
- Lee uses Atticus to represent the qualities that will help make society a better place:
  - Walter Cunningham is welcomed into the Finch home for a meal, despite the difficult economic situation of the time
  - Atticus employs Calpurnia and treats her well, despite prejudice towards black women:
    - He keeps her in employment during the **Great Depression**, when there were likely many white women looking for work
- Through his insistence that it is a sin kill a mockingbird, Atticus is presented as believing that innocence should be protected:
  - He protects the vulnerable of the town by telling the children to leave Boo Radley alone, and by

Jem Finch

Jem Finch

- Jem is kind, mature and even tempered and is portrayed as a protective older brother to Scout:
  - When he catches his sister fighting with Walter Cunningham, he reprimands her and invites him round for dinner
  - This demonstrates the kindness and generosity of spirit he has learned from his father
- Although all of the children are fascinated by Boo Radley, Jem demonstrates leadership in a number of instances:
  - He takes charge of the idea to re-enact Boo's life, casting himself as the lead character
  - It is Jem who runs to the Radleys' front porch to touch the front door
  - He protects Scout by telling her to run away during the Bob Ewell attack
- Lee presents Jem as intelligent and thoughtful, but also emotional:
  - When Nathan Radley seals the tree hole where the children find gifts, Jem is upset
  - In a fit of anger, he cuts Mrs Dubose's camellia flowers, signifying his desire to cut intolerance out of his community:
    - After her death, he throws the flower she left for him into the fire
- As the novel progresses, Jem is presented as more mature than Scout, choosing to isolate himself and spend time reading instead of playing:
  - Jem's **introspection** coincides with the beginning of the second part of the novel, bringing an end to the age of innocence at the start
  - Jem's **adherence** to rules evolves over time, suggesting an understanding of the complexity of right and wrong:
    - During the midnight scene at the jail, he demonstrates a willingness to accept punishment rather than betray his father's trust
- Jem's character undergoes a **profound** shift following Tom Robinson's conviction:

society, Jem grapples with **disillusionment** and questions the **inherent** goodness of people
        - Despite this, like his father, he wants to become a lawyer so he can make a positive impact on the world

Boo Radley

Boo Radley

- Although Boo Radley is rarely seen in the novel, the symbolism of his character is central to the novel
- Boo is presented as being tormented by the children, who are fascinated by rumours that he stabbed his father with scissors and has been confined to the house ever since:
    - Described as a "**malevolent** phantom" by Scout at the beginning, it is Boo who saves her life with an act of bravery and selflessness at the end:
        - As such, he symbolises innocence, kindness and the **juxtaposition** of **hearsay** and reality
- He is **ostracised** by the community and stigmatised as an outsider to be feared and shunned as he does not adhere to **social norms**:
    - He is a motif for those who are **marginalised** due to ignorance and rumour
    - He leaves gifts for the children in the hollow of a tree, suggesting he is **benevolent** and desires friendship and human connection:
        - The tree is filled in with cement, signifying social barriers that keep people apart and **hinder** understanding
- After saving Scout and Jem from Bob Ewell, Lee presents Boo as gentle and vulnerable:
    - He asks to be taken home: "He almost whispered it, in the voice of a child afraid of the dark"
- Scout's realisation at the end of the novel that Boo seems "real nice" is symbolic of her evolution and maturity:
    - This represents the novel's central message that people should be treated fairly and not discriminated against

Calpurnia

Calpurnia

- As the sole female presence in Scout's predominantly male household at the beginning of the novel, Calpurnia serves as a strong role model for Scout:
  - She assumes the role of a teacher, imparting valuable life lessons to Scout and Jem, helping them to understand the intricacies of racial and social divides
- By introducing them to her congregation, Calpurnia allows them to experience an aspect of African-American culture:
  - Scout and Jem's visit to the church expands their horizons and enhances their comprehension of social justice
- Throughout the novel, Calpurnia exhibits strength of character and upholds admirable morals:
  - Like Atticus, Calpurnia refrains from passing judgement on others, **reprimanding** Scout for doing so when she comments on Walter's eating habits
- In the era of segregation in the American south, Calpurnia exemplifies resilience and dignity:
  - Her portrayal epitomises the resilience of the black community during a time of pervasive oppression

Dill (Charles Baker Harris)

- Dill is a playmate for Scout and Jem whose presence is associated with the school holidays, games and adventures:
  - He symbolises the happiness and innocence of childhood in contrast to the complex issues Scout and Jem later encounter
- Although he is not from Maycomb, Dill is accepted into the community:
  - This contrasts with the experience of other characters such as Tom Robinson and Boo Radley
- As children, Dill and Scout plan to marry when they are adults:
  - This **alludes** to a young understanding of accepted social norms and the impressionability of children

Bob Ewell

Bob Ewell

- Bob Ewell is the **antagonist** of the novel, epitomising racial hatred in the story:
  - Atticus reveals that Bob is responsible for his daughter's injuries, having caught her trying to kiss Tom Robinson because he is black:
    - As such, he symbolises racial hatred and is used by Lee to attack the **grotesqueness** of segregation and racism in America
- Bob Ewell is a **foil** of Atticus, whose racist attitudes and moral corruption set a bad example to his children:
  - "As Judge Taylor banged his gavel, Mr Ewell was sitting smugly in the witness chair, surveying his handiwork"
- In attacking Mayella Ewell and trying to kill Scout and Jem, Bob represents the harm that hatred is able to wreak:
  - The portrayal of him living at the dump is not only a commentary on poverty and class, but also on the **depravity** of his attitudes

Mayella Ewell

Mayella Ewell

- Mayella Ewell is the oldest daughter of Bob Ewell and accuses Tom Robinson of raping her
- As a character, she does not appear until Chapter 18 when she gives her testimony in court:
  - Despite her false accusation, Lee invites the reader to feel some sympathy for her due to her miserable home circumstances

Tom Robinson

Tom Robinson

- Tom Robinson, a black man, stands as a **poignant** symbol of the injustice that plagues Maycomb:
  - Harper Lee depicts him as a hardworking family man wrongfully convicted of rape he did not commit:
    - Tom's portrayal as a compassionate and honest character challenges the dehumanising stereotypes perpetuated by society
- By describing the injustice of Tom's fate, Lee forces readers to consider the prejudices ingrained within the legal system and society at large:
  - His experience and subsequent death serve as a reminder of the devastating impact of racism and the need for justice and equality

Mrs Dubose

Mrs Dubose

- Mrs Dubose is portrayed as a stark embodiment of the racial prejudices deeply ingrained within Maycomb society
- Jem does not want to be in her presence but Atticus makes Jem read to her as a punishment for cutting her camelia flowers:
  - Their encounters with her expose the children to the harsh realities of racism and social injustice
  - They witness her illness and discomfort and learn about her history of addiction:
    - It becomes a **pivotal** moment in their moral education, emphasising the importance of confronting prejudice and fostering empathy

Aunt Alexandra

Aunt Alexandra

- Aunt Alexandra is portrayed as a traditional and conservative character:
  - She can be seen as the **antithesis** of her brother, Atticus
  - She embodies a rigid conception of femininity that stands in contrast to the more unconventional roles embraced by characters like Calpurnia and Scout:
    - Her presence serves as a reminder of the societal expectations placed upon women in Maycomb, highlighting the tensions between tradition and progress in the novel

Miss Maudie Atkinson

Miss Maudie Atkinson

- Miss Maudie Atkinson is one of the Finch's neighbours in Maycomb
- She is depicted as a kind and compassionate character and provides a source of comfort and understanding for the children
- She has progressive views that stand in contrast to the rest of Maycomb society

Sources:

Lee, H. (2010). To Kill a Mockingbird. Arrow Books.

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